

Unit 1

Perception and Dreaming

Content overview

Topic A: How do we see our world?

This topic focuses on perception and illusions, drawing on biological and cognitive psychology.

Topic B: Is dreaming meaningful?

This topic addresses Freud's dream theory and the theory of activation synthesis.

Assessment overview

- Assessed through an external examination.
- The paper consists of multiple-choice and short-answer questions, and lasts 1 hour and 15 minutes.
- There are 60 marks in the examination and the result contributes 40% of the total grade for the full GCSE.

Detailed unit content

Topic A How do we see our world?

1. Explaining the question: How do we see our world?

Students will be assessed on their understanding of:

- a the biological structures involved in perception: including the role of
 - i the eye (retina, rods, cones, optic nerve, blind spot)
 - ii the brain (-optic chiasma, visual cortex)
- b cues to depth: superimposition, relative size, linear perspective, stereopsis, texture gradient, height in the plane; and size constancy
- c Gestalt laws: figure-ground, continuity, proximity, similarity, closure
- d visual illusions: fictions (colour after-effects and illusory contours), ambiguous figures (Necker cube and Leeper's lady), distortions (Muller-Lyer and Ponzo)
- e explanations of illusions (Gestalt theory and Gregory's work on perspective theory), including evaluation of each
- f the influence of schemas on how we interpret our world and evaluation of such influence drawing on Palmer (1975), Bartlett (1932) and Carmichael, Hogan and Walter (1932).

Note: In the examination, students could be asked to demonstrate their understanding of stimulus material drawing on key terms and explanations.

2.

Investigating the question: Laboratory experiments

Students will be assessed on their understanding of:

- a the following terms, and their use when referring to methodology:
 - i independent variable
 - ii dependent variable
 - iii experimental hypothesis
 - iv experimental (participant) design: repeated measures and
 - v independent groups
 - vi descriptive statistics (mean, median, mode, range)
 - vii bar chart
 - viii control of variables
 - ix informed consent
 - x right to withdraw

In the examination, students could be asked to design an experiment from stimulus material, drawing on the terms above.

- b the ethical issues in laboratory experiments of informed consent and the right to withdraw, and how these may be dealt with
- c the laboratory experiment as a research method including evaluation
- d the aims, procedure, and findings (results and/or conclusions) and evaluation of
 - i Palmer (1975) *The effects of contextual scenes on the identification of objects*
 - ii Bartlett (1932) *War of the Ghosts*
 - iii Carmichael, Hogan and Walter (1932) *An experimental study of the effect of language on the reproduction of visually perceived forms.*

3.

Why psychology matters

Students will be assessed on their understanding of:

- a how eyewitness memory can be influenced by schemas drawing on two studies; and the importance of these influences for society and/or the individual.

Note: In the examination, students could be asked to demonstrate their understanding of stimulus material drawing on key terms and explanations.